Activity: IEEE VIS 2026

DATA 3302: Data Visualization, Fall 2026
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Contents

I Activity Overview 1
II Choosing papers 1
Earn extra credit by asking a question 1
III Deliverable 2
IV Oral interview 2
V Grading 2

I Activity Overview

IEEE VIS is the premier venue for visualization research, and this semester it overlaps with our class. Rather than a lecture on what the field is currently doing, you will go and see it for yourself. For each class session we miss for the conference, you will watch a talk from IEEE VIS and read the paper behind it.

The point is to learn how visualization research is actually presented, argued, and evaluated, and to build the habit of reading papers critically and applying what they find to your own work. This also directly supports your final project, which requires you to engage with this literature.

In this activity you will:

- Watch a talk (live or recorded) and read the corresponding paper, for at least **five** different papers, one for each class session that is missed.
- Write a short summary of each paper, covering its methods and key findings.
- Identify one way each paper could inform one of the assignments in this class.
- Pass a short oral interview about one of your papers.

II Choosing papers

Papers may come from IEEE VIS **2024**, **2025**, or **2026**. Each of the five must be a different paper, and you should aim for a spread of topics rather than five papers on the same subject.

- The 2026 program is at ieeevis.org/year/2026/program/sessions and the individual papers are listed at ieeevis.org/year/2026/program/content. Many of the talks will be livestreamed.
- Recordings of earlier years, and potentially of 2026 after the fact, are on the IEEE VIS YouTube channel.

If a paper is not accessible, such as having no preprint or OSF link, email me and I will send you the PDF.

Earn extra credit by asking a question

If you read a paper *before* its scheduled talk and email me a question about it before the talk, I will go to that talk and try to ask your question. Papers handled this way earn additional credit toward your participation grade. Make the question specific to the paper, ideally about a design or methodological choice, rather than something its abstract already answers.

III Deliverable

Submit a single PDF to Gradescope, with a section for each paper. Each section should be short, a half page is plenty, and include:

- The full citation, and a link to the paper and the talk you watched.
- A summary of the paper: the problem it addresses, its methods, and its key findings.
- One way in which the paper could be relevant to one of the assignments in this class, stated specifically. What would you change or try, and why?
- If you emailed a question beforehand, the question.

Write the summaries in your own words. Remember that your final project revision must engage with this literature, so papers relevant to your own work are a good place to start looking.

IV Oral interview

In order to receive participation credit you must pass a short oral interview about one of your submitted papers, chosen at random. Interviews will take place during the remaining lab time or during office hours. I will ask you to explain what the paper did, why, and what it found, and to discuss how you would apply it. You will not be considered to have completed the activity until you have done this, so do not leave it until the last week.

V Grading

This lab activity is not part of any standalone graded assessment. It is graded for completion only, and counts toward your overall participation grade. A missing or incomplete submission, or not completing the interview, will affect that grade.